

A "first internal builder" project brief

How to find the one banker on your team who can build, not just use.

Every community bank has one person — often a younger analyst, a recent hire, an operations associate — who could build a small internal AI workflow if given permission and a target. Naming that person early matters more than buying a vendor solution.

What makes someone a candidate

- Curiosity about how things work, not just whether they work
- Comfort writing — emails, memos, documentation
- Has shown up to one of your safe-sandbox sessions on their own
- Is not currently the IT department (the goal is operational, not technical)
- Has demonstrated good judgment with sensitive information

The first project

Pick a single department. Operations is usually the easiest.

Pick a single repetitive task. Drafting standard customer response letters. Compiling weekly exception reports. Summarizing the policy manual for new hires.

Set a 30-day boundary. The builder works on it for one hour a day. At day 30 they show what they made to the department head. The artifact is internal-only, no customer data, no production use.

Three things you can do this week

1. **Identify the candidate.** One person, by name.
2. **Give them the brief.** Walk them through the boundaries: one department, one task, 30 days, internal-only, no PII.
3. **Block 30 minutes on day 30** to review what they built.

A starter prompt for the builder

I am building a small internal AI workflow for our [department] team's [task]. The workflow must use only public or synthetic information — no customer data, no internal financial figures. Help me design the workflow in three steps: (1) what input the workflow takes, (2) what the AI tool does with that input, (3) what output a banker reviews before it is used. Keep the design simple enough that I can build it in 30 days at one hour per day.

Why this matters

The institutions that compound AI capability over the next three years will be the ones that develop internal builders, not the ones that buy the most vendor solutions. One named builder beats one unnamed budget every time.

Citations

- AI Playbook for Banks and Credit Unions, Cornerstone Advisors, 2025
- Hybrid Multi-Cloud AI Strategy, SS&C Managed IT, 2025